

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1998-02-17

1 dear bahá'í friends,
2 in which you forwarded a question from one of the members of your bahá'í
3 community . . . regarding the recourse of the friends when they believe an Assembly
has made an error. we are to reply as follows.
4 first, it is important to consider the unique nature of the bahá'í Adminis-
5 trative order, and the responsibilities of the individuals and the institutions
6 within it. As . . . is no doubt aware, in the bahá'í system, the individual votes
7 for the members of the Spiritual Assembly with the understanding that she or he is
free to choose without any interference whomever his conscience prompts him to select, and
freely accepts the authority of the outcome. Sub-mission of the believers to the decisions of
the Assembly is essential to the

achievement and maintenance of unity within the community. in the act

8 of voting, the individual subscribes to a covenant by which the orderliness
9 of society is upheld. The Assembly has the responsibility to guide, direct and decide
on community affairs and the right to be obeyed and supported
10 by members of the community. The individual has the responsibility to es-
11 tablish and maintain the Assembly through election, the offering of advice, moral
support and material assistance; and he has the right to be heard by it,
12 to receive its guidance and assistance, and to appeal any Assembly decision
13 which he conscientiously feels is unjust or detrimental to the community.
14 concerning the accountability of the Spiritual Assemblies, the guardian
15 in God Passes By (p. 331) wrote that the Assemblies are "invested with an
16 authority rendering them unanswerable for their acts and decisions to those who
elect them," and that they are "solemnly pledged to follow, under all conditions, the dictates
of the 'most great justice' that can alone usher in
17 the reign of the 'most great peace' which bahá'u'lláh has proclaimed and
18 must ultimately establish." The Assemblies are therefore responsible to god
19 rather than to those who elect them.

The attitude of the believer towards the Assembly decisions should be

20 one of wholehearted acceptance and support. if, however, the individual 257 .1

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259 607feels that a decision is incorrect, he is free to bring additional information

260 pertaining to the matter to the Assembly for its consideration. Should the

261 decision remain unchanged, it is preferable if he accepts humbly the view of

262 the Assembly in the spirit of sacrifice, and without further dispute. Then, as the
master has affirmed, any wrong decision will eventually be set right.

263 when the believers act submissively and in the spirit of self-effacement it

264 attracts the good pleasure of god, which in itself serves as a consolation to

265 their hearts.

266 A believer who is distressed by the decision reached by an Assembly may

267 well find comfort and reassurance in the following passage from a letter written on
behalf of Shoghi e f fendi:

268 The Assembly may make a mistake, but, as the master pointed out,

if the community does not abide by its decisions, or the individual

269 bahá'í, the result is worse, as it undermines the very institution which

must be strengthened in order to uphold the principles and laws of

the faith. he tells us god will right the wrongs done. we must have

270 confidence in this and obey our Assemblies. . . .

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272 if, after taking all this into account, a believer is still unsatisfied with a

273 decision of the Assembly, he can appeal, in the first instance, to his National

274 ever, in so doing it is advisable to bear in mind that such a dissenting voice

275 should make itself heard only within the proper administrative institutions and never
elsewhere. once such a case has been presented to the institutions

276 it is no longer the responsibility of that individual and should be left in the care of
those divinely ordained agencies.

277 The same appeal process applies to an individual who has lost his voting

278 rights, should he feel that they have been unjustly removed. when a believer

279 is deprived of his administrative rights, he is entitled to clear information on the
requirements to be fulfilled in order that his rights may be restored; these may include the
passage of a prescribed period of time, the performance of

280 certain remedial actions, or the alteration of an attitude or pattern of behav-
281 ior which is considered unworthy or harmful. A condition for the restoration

282 257-1. lg, no. 283.257 .5

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258 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

259 608of voting rights is that the believer be sincerely repentant, as evidenced by
260 his statement to that effect or by his demeanor and conduct.

261 The house of justice hopes that the foregoing has sufficiently addressed

262 . . . 's question and wishes to assure her of its love for her.

263 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

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Establishment of Three New National Spiritual

Assemblies, Reestablishment of One

National Spiritual Assembly

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]